

Capstone Project Report

Integrating Biomass Combustion and Anaerobic Digestion with CHP Systems for Circular
Energy Management in Food Processing Industries

Prepared by:

Aadil Shekh (9013053)

Ravi Patel (8998831)

Arsalan Azhar (9014159)

Chirag Patel (8943672)

Alarabiat Mohammad (8993568)

Chandrika Solleti (9018186)

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Professor: Arcadio Goody

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2. ABSTRACT:

In Canada the food processing sector produces a volume of organic waste over 11 million tonnes per year and is a highly energy consuming sector of the industry. This two-fold problem, which results in large amounts of waste produced and large amounts of fossil-fuel energy used, causes economical inefficiencies and is a major contributor to the national greenhouse gases (GHGs) emissions. The report considers both technical and financial viability of a circular waste-to-energy system of a large food processing plant that produces 60 tonnes/day of mixed organic waste.

The solution proposed combines anaerobic digestion with biomass combustion with the use of the idea of Combined Heat and Power (CHP) to produce renewable electricity, thermal power, and nutrient-rich digestate. It is estimated that the facility can produce between 7,500 and 9,800 m³/day of biogas or 15,000 to 20,000 kWh/day of integrated electrical and thermal power of the CHP system through engineering calculations. It is estimated that the system will realize a 40-52 percentage of GHG emissions reduction, which can be compared with federal 2030 climate targets.

A financial feasibility analysis, comprising of capital-cost estimates, operating-costs, cash-flow predictions, sensitivity analysis, and the carbon-credit evaluation allows one to understand that the integrated system will achieve an economically viable state within 6.8 to 9.5 years, in accordance to the conditions on the market. The system also promotes the circular economy through the minimization of landfill waste, the renewable energy recovery, and the creation of useful by-products, including digestate fertilizer and heat to be used in the industrial processes.

The report also concludes that the proposed design is technically viable and financially reasonable and environmentally positive as a long-term decarbonization strategy of the food processing industry.

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6. INTRODUCTION:

Food processing industry is significant to the economic growth and food security in Canada but at the same time, it has been one of the greatest sources of industrial waste and energy consumption. In 2024, there were over 11 million tonnes of food waste being produced at the country level, and much of it came because of processing plants. Mixed wastes- such as fruit, vegetables, meat, dairy, bakery wastes and packaging wastes- pose considerable operational and environmental challenge. The common ways of disposing such wastes are landfill or composting, both of which lead to fugitive methane emissions and wasted bioenergy potential.

Meanwhile, thermal processing of food products undertaken in food processing facilities is reliant on fossil fuels and bought grid electricity to execute operations like drying, sterilization, refrigeration, and packaging. By 2020, the sector consumed about 33.9 petajoules of energy, fossil fuels taking up the majority of the share. This exposes financial weaknesses by its unpredictable energy costs and adds to the industrial levels of greenhouse gases (GHG) in Canada.

To overcome these issues, the present report considers a high-impact technological pathway that includes biomass combustion, anaerobic digestion (AD), and Combined Heat and Power (CHP) to develop the system of circular energy management in a food processing plant with 60 tonnes/day of mixed organic waste.

The goal is to develop and test a system that:

- Their conversion of organic waste to renewable energy.
- Minimizes the use of fossil fuel.
- Reduces GHG emissions (more than 40%).
- Facilitates the circular economy model of closed loop nature.

- Improves operational resiliency and energy security.
- Shows economic viability in the long-term.

The offered design can be associated with the Emissions Reduction Plan of Canada in 2030 and the international shift to environmentally friendly industrial activities.

7. PROBLEM DEFINITION & PROPOSAL STATEMENT:

7.1 Problem Definition

In Canada, the food processing industry provides a contribution to the food security of a country, economic growth and employment. Nonetheless, it also has two significant structural problems, which jeopardize its long-term sustainability: a massive production of organic waste and a high reliance on the use of fossil fuels.

A. Overproduction of Organic Wastes.

The plant with the capacity of 60 tonnes/day of mixed organic waste is part of a much greater national problem: Canada produces over 11 million tonnes of food waste every year. In food processing facilities, the waste streams are fruit and vegetable peels and trimmings, meat and poultry waste, dairy by-products, starchy heavy wastes and plant fibrous wastes.

The following waste streams are very problematic:

1. Environmental Impact

- In landfills, organic matter breaks down anaerobically producing methane (CH₄).
- Methane is 25 times more harmful to the environment than CO₂.

- Food waste contributes to one of the biggest sources of methane in the Canadian landfills.

2. Economic Burden

- Direct costs include landfill tipping fees that are between 80-140 per tonne in Ontario.
- There is extra overhead of transportation and handling.
- The presence of organic waste diversion requirements will also add to the cost of regulatory compliance.

3. Lost Resource Value

- Food waste contains a lot of energy and nutrients.
- Landfilling loses the production of renewable energy and recovering fertilizer.
- Such effects underscore the necessity of converting waste to energy in food processing plants.

B. Consumption and Dependence on Fossil Fuels of a high energy nature.

The food processing is energy-consuming by nature, because of using the following processes:

- Pasteurization and blanching.
- Cooking and sterilization
- Refrigeration and freezing
- Drying and evaporation

- Containerization and systems conveying.

This plant will need large quantities of:

- Motors, cooling systems, automation (electricity).
- Hot water systems (Natural Gas, boilers, process heat)

Key challenges include:

1. High Operating Costs.

Energy is one of the biggest cost centers in the manufacturing. Financial pressure increases with increasing utility rates.

2. GHG Emission and Carbon Liability.

CO₂ is emitted by the combustion of natural gas, whereas grid electricity does not become clean even in Ontario with its relatively clean grid mix.

3. Energy Security Risks

The reliance on foreign sources of energy exposes them to price fluctuations and supply disturbances.

C. Existing Waste and Energy Systems Inefficiencies.

Current waste management systems and energy supply systems follow a linear and silo-based operation:

- Waste is generated → transported → disposed
- Energy is purchased → consumed → emitted

This linear model does not reflect the nature of synergies between waste production and energy consumption within the food processing processes.

The inability to integrate leads to:

- High GHG emissions Increasing disposal and energy prices.
- Lack of exploiting renewable energy.
- Late entry in the circular economy.

D. Regulatory and Market Drivers.

Increasing pressure in the food processing industry is coming at the hands of:

- The mandatory diversion of landfills.
- Increased emission regulation.
- Carbon pricing policies Expectations in terms of corporate sustainability.
- The demand of the consumer towards environmentally responsible brands.

With new regulations being stricter, the facilities that do not adapt to them face the risk of operating at high costs and getting a damaged reputation.

7.2 Proposal Statement

As a solution to these related problems this project offers to design and do feasibility study to an integrated circular energy system, converting the organic waste into renewable energy to power the facility itself.

The proposed system incorporates three technologies which have been proven to be effective:

A. Anaerobic Digestion (AD)

Transforms high moisture organic waste (fruits, vegetables, dairy, meat residues) to:

- Biogas (used as fuel for CHP)
- Fertilizer (substituted by digestate, which is a synthetic product)

B. Biomass Combustion

Dry fibrous residues of peels, shells, husks, wood-like residues are dried by converts to:

- High-temperature heat
- Substitution of natural gas in thermal operations.

C. Combined Heat and Power (CHP)

Gets biogas to concomitantly produce:

- Electricity that is renewed to operate the plant.
- Thermal load recoverable heat.

CHP has efficiency of 75-85% thus an ideal fit to food facility energy profiles.

7.2.1 Scope of the Proposed Project

This capstone project includes:

1. Engineering Design

- Sizing of AD digester Calculations of biogas and methane.
- Estimation of boiler size and thermal capacity of biomass boilers.
- Specification and energy recovery analysis of CHP system.
- Layout of integration and process flow description.

2. Feasibility (Main Focus) Assessment.

- Technical feasibility (waste properties, working with the process, performance)
Operational capability (staffing, servicing and uptime anticipations)
- Green Mile Organization (GHG reductions, regulatory alignment)
- Environmental Feasibility:
 - CAPEX and OPEX modeling
 - NPV, IRR, and payback analysis
 - Carbon credit valuation
 - Sensitivity analysis

3. Circular Economy and Integration of Sustainability.

- Waste → energy → digestate loop
- Less dependability on landfills.
- Renewable energy adoption
- Fostering the agricultural nutrient loops.

4. Pathway of High-Level Implementation.

The project map gives a roadmap of actions to follow but fails to incorporate the prototype construction.

It focuses on:

- Conceptual engineering
- System modeling
- Performance calculations
- Economic and ecological rationality.

7.2.2 Expected Outcomes

The project aims to:

- Reduce GHG emissions by 40-50%
- 1.2525-35% Offset electricity and 0.6080% offset heat requirement.
- Cut down the waste-disposal volumes by 90%+
- Give good financial payback (7-10-year payback)
- Present a replicable example that can be applicable to the Canadian food processing industry.
- Polis, the national climate objectives and the principles of the circular economy.

8. DESIGN REQUIREMENTS

This section presents technical requirement, functionality requirement, operational requirement, environmental requirement and financial requirement that the proposed integrated waste-to-energy system will fulfill. These demands form the basis of determining the design performance and the possible implementation of the same in a 60-tonne/day food processing plant.

The following were the sources of design requirements:

- Features of organic waste produced by the facility.
- Power requirements are common to large scale food preparation facilities.
- Regulation Preparation of waste diversion and emission regulation frameworks.
- Placing principles of a circular economy.
- Industrial capital projects: financial expectations.
- Planned items in the initial project proposal.

Such requirements make the system workable, effective, cost-effective, regulatory, and consistent with more global sustainability objectives.

8.1. Functional Requirements (FRs)

Functional requirements provide an outline on what the system will be required to achieve in addressing project goals.

FR1 – Waste Processing Capacity

The system must:

- Mixed food processing waste high-moisture and high-lignin fractions 60 tonnes/day.
- Work efficiently with changes in feedstock make up.
- Continuous and stable operation [?]90% uptime.

Measurement:

Daily throughput (tonnes/day), plain capacity -30-85%.

FR2 – Biogas Production Performance

The AD system should be able to transform volatile solids into biogas which will be sufficient to power CHP activities.

Requirements:

- Minimum biogas yield: 0.45 m³/kg VS
- Target biogas volume: 7,000-9,500 m³/day
- Methane concentration: [?]55%

Measurement:

Reading of biogas meter, laboratory BMP testing.

FR3 – Energy Generation and Recovery

The cohesive system has to produce a significant amount of electricity and thermal energy to the facility.

Required Outputs:

- Electrical: [?] 5,000-7,000 kWh/day from CHP
- Thermal: [?] 15,000-20,000 kWh/day of heat recovery of CHP.
- Additional Thermal: [?] 18,000-15,000 kWh/day biomass burning.

Measurement:

LSCHP and boiler performance logs, energy monitoring SCADA based.

FR4 – Digestate and Ash Utilization

The AD and biomass processes should have their outputs handled in a sustainable manner.

Requirements:

- According to CFIA requirements, digestate must be suitable to be used in agriculture.
- The ash generated by biomass boiler should be non-poisonous, and it should be used as the soil amendment when possible.

Measurement:

Digestate nutrient profile, CFIA complaint.

FR5 – System Integration and Automation

The integrated plant should be functioning as a unit.

Requirements:

- Automatic feedstock organisation.
- Biogas pressure and H₂S monitoring (safety control).
- Thermal loop integration.
- On-demand tracking of energy flows.

Measurement:

PLC/SCADA uptime automated control system performance.

8.2. Performance Requirements (PRs)

The requirements state the quantitative performance targets that shall be attained by the system to be declared successful.

PR1 – CHP Efficiency

CHP system should be able to attain industry-targets of efficiencies:

- Electrical efficiency: [?] 30-40%
- Thermal efficiency: [?] 40-50%
- Combined efficiency: [?] 75%

Measurement:

Shear stress, heater/cooler, power consumption and specification, specifications by a manufacturer.

PR2 – Boiler Performance

The biomass boiler must:

- Achieve [?] 65-75% thermal efficiency.
- completeness of moisture-waste streams, fibrous.
- Stabilized combustion of minimal intermittency.

Measurement:

Check-up of boiler combustion efficiency, flue gas.

PR3 – Process Stability

AD system should be stable to different waste pleas.

Requirements:

- pH level: 6.8-7.4
- Volatile fatty acid (VFA) ratio: [?] 0.4<|human|>Volatile fatty acid (VFA) ratio: [?]
0.4<|human|>Volatile fatty acid (VFA) ratio: [?]
- 0.4<|human|>Volatile fatty acid (VFA) ratio: [?] 0.4<|human|>Volatile fatty acid (VFA)
ratio: [?] 0.4
- Organic loading rate (OLR): 3-6 kg VS/m³-day

Measurement:

laboratory tests and records of operators.

PR4 – Energy Offset Requirement**The system must:**

- Balance [?] 25-35% of total electricity demand.
- Offset [?] 6-80% of total demand of thermal energy.
- Less reliance on electric grid and natural gas.

Measurement:

Comparison of pre and after installation utility bills.

8.3. Environmental and Regulatory Requirements (ERs)**ER1 – GHG Emission Reduction Target**

The system should be able to cause a 40 percent decrease in the total plant emissions compared to the operations carried out in the base period.

Achieved via:

- Avoided landfill methane.
- Natural gas combustion that is displaced.
- Less electricity levying on the grid.

Measurement:

Annual reduction of CO₂e through approved emission factors.

ER2 – Compliance with Provincial and Federal Regulations

Requirements Include:

- Policy Ontario Food and Organic Waste.
- CSA B149 Gas Code (biogas safety)
- MOECC standards of air-emission.
- CFIA rules of quality in digestates.

Measurement:

Allowing and compliance audit reports.

ER3 – Minimal Environmental Impact

The system must ensure:

- Odor control

- None of the water pollution of the ground.
- Secure gas handling
- Adequate discharge of waste water.

Measurement:

Report on environmental monitoring.

8.4. Economic and Financial Requirements (FiRs)

Financial measures will reveal the viability of the system to work on long-term basis.

FiR1 — Capital Cost Threshold

Total CAPEX must remain within industry benchmarks:

- Target: \$11-15 million
- Ideally, less than the benchmark of [?] 250,000 per tonne/day capacity.

Measurement:

Vendor quotations, cost model validation.

FiR2 — Operating Cost Limits

Annual OPEX must not exceed:

- \$1.2-1.5 million/year

Measurement:

Annual review of operations expenditure.

FiR3 — Payback Period Requirement

Payback period must be:

- [?] 10 years (acceptable)
- 6-9 years (ideal range)

Measurement:

Results of financial evaluation (Section 12).

FiR4 — Profitability Metrics

The project must demonstrate:

- Positive NPV over 20-year life
- IRR [?] 8-10%
- Benefit-Cost Ratio > 1.0

Measurement:

Discounted cash flow (DCF) analysis.

FiR5 — Carbon Credit Revenue Eligibility

The system must qualify for:

- Federal carbon pricing
- Clean Fuel Standard credits
- Possible voluntary carbon markets.

Minimum Target Revenue:

- \$300k-\$600k per year by 2030

Measurement:

Confirmation according to accepted carbon offset schemes.

8.5. Operational Requirements (ORs)**OR1 — Staffing & Training****The facility must be operable by:**

- 1 operations supervisor
- 3-4 plant technicians
- 1 maintenance operator

Training must include:

- Biogas safety
- Boiler operations
- CHP maintenance
- Process control systems

OR2 — Equipment Maintainability**Requirements:**

- Availability of OEM support
- Spare parts within 48-72 hours

- Scheduling shut down windows annually.
- Sensors are needed to predictive maintenance.

OR3 — System Availability and Reliability

Target uptime: $\geq 90\%$

Redundancies:

- Backup pumps
- Dual-feedstock lines
- Emergency flare for biogas
- Thermal storage buffer tank

8.6. Table of Key Design Requirements

Category	Requirement	Target
Waste Capacity	Daily processing	60 tonnes/day
Biogas Production	Yield	7,000–9,500 m³/day
CHP Output	Electricity	5,000–7,000 kWh/day
CHP Output	Thermal	15,000–20,000 kWh/day
Biomass Heat	Thermal	15,000–18,000 kWh/day
GHG Reduction	Annual CO₂e reduction	$\geq 40\%$
CAPEX	Target cost	\$11–15M

Payback	Acceptable range	6–10 years
NPV	Must be positive	✓ Requirement
IRR	Minimum	≥ 8%
System Uptime	Reliability	≥ 90%

9. BACKGROUND INFORMATION

This section gives the scientific, technical, and industry background that is required to comprehend the problem and the solution proposed. It forms the basis of knowledge on anaerobic digestion, biomass combustion and CHP integration in a food processing environment.

9.1 Organic Food Processing Industry Waste.

The food processing industry produces various waste products, such as fruit peels, vegetable trimmings, animal wastes, dairy wastes, expired packaged food products, high volumes of starch materials, and fibrous plant materials. These solid waste streams are commonly composed of:

- High moisture content (65–85%)
- High volatile solids (VS), which are biodegradable.
- High potential energy (Biological or thermal conversion).

Waste Typical Characteristics (Mixed Food Waste)

A mixed waste stream with a weight of 60 tonne/day is typical with the following composition:

- Total Solids (TS): 25–35%
- Volatile Solids (VS): 80–92% of TS
- Biochemical Methane Potential (BMP): 0.45-0.60 m³ CH₄/ kg VS.

The waste of the food industry can make a perfect anaerobic digestion feedstock due to such high biodegradability. In the meantime, dry waste fractions (shells, husks, woody residues) can be used in the combustion of biomass.

9.2 The problem of landfilling organic waste

Food waste disposal in a landfill poses environmental and economic problems:

Environmental Impacts

- produces methane (CH₄), which is a GHG that is 25 times more warming than CO₂.
- Gives rise to leachate, which is treated at an expensive cost.
- Added to odor, pests and community issues.

Economic Impacts

- Raising the tipping charges in landfills (80-140 range in Ontario).
- Methane carbon (under Canada carbon tax) costs.

Regulatory Pressure

The province of Ontario has the Food and Organic Waste Policy Statement (2023) according to which industrial, commercial, and institutional (IC&I) sectors should prevent the dumping of organic waste in landfills. The legislation is very pro onsite or regional waste-to-energy systems.

9.3 Energy use in Food Processing plants.

Heat and electricity are essential to food processing plants because they are used in:

- Pasteurization & blanching
- Sterilization and cooking
- Drying and evaporation
- Refrigeration and chilling
- Conveyor system and packaging.

In a number of facilities, thermal energy consumes 60-70% of the total energy. Natural gas is used to provide most of the heat with electricity being purchased off the grid.

Such intensified consumption of fossil fuels triggers:

- High operational costs
- Risks of fluctuation in energy prices.
- Large carbon footprints
- Problems in the realization of sustainability targets.

9.4 Anaerobic digestion (AD) overview

Anaerobic digestion is a biological process in which some microorganisms decompose organic matter in the absence of oxygen producing:

- Biogas (50–65% methane, 35–45% CO₂)
- Fertilizer (digestate) which is nutritious.

AD is popular in agricultural, wastewater, and industrial sectors.

Advantages of AD:

- High yields of biogas on food waste.
- Lessens the landfill methane emissions.
- Generates renewable power and energy.
- Makes its own digestate substituting artificial fertilizers.

AD is regarded to be one of the best technologies of waste-to-energy in this industry because food waste is highly biodegradable.

9.5 Biomass Combustion Overview

The biomass combustion is the heat energy that is generated through controlled burning of dry organic matter. Some of the biomass fractions that are appropriate in food plants are:

- Nut shells
- Husk residues
- Dry pulp
- Wood-like waste

Biomass Combustion has the following benefits:

- Immediate heat production
- Bonuses AD with dry waste fractions.
- Lowers the boiler consumption of natural gas.

- Has a low net carbon emission.

This is a thermal output that is perfect when heating processes.

9.6 Overview of Combined Heat and Power (CHP).

CHP systems (cogeneration systems):

- Burn biogas (or natural gas) in generator.
- Produce electricity
- Form harvests exhaust jacket water of the engine to provide industrial processes.

Efficiency Benefits:

- The efficiency of traditional power plants is 35-40%.
- CHP systems have a total efficiency of 75-85% efficiency.

This qualifies CHP to be the ideal option in food processing plants which need both heat and electricity at the same time.

9.7 Circular Economy Benefits

The closed-loop model is made with the help of the integrated system:

1. The waste is used to generate energy.
2. Plant operations are powered with energy.
3. Carbon emission is minimized to the lowest.

This minimizes environmental impact and enhances economic performance which is a fundamental aspect of the circular economy strategies.

12. Evaluation

12.1 Engineering Calculations

The integrated system was evaluated for its energy and material outputs based on the feedstock of 60 t/day mixed organic waste:

- **Anaerobic Digestion (AD):**
 - Biogas yield: 7,500–9,800 m³/day
 - Methane content: 55–60%
 - Digestate output: ~15–18 t/day (wet basis)
- **Biomass Combustion:**
 - Thermal output: 15,000–18,000 kWh/day
 - Ash production: ~1–1.2 t/day, suitable for soil amendment
- **Combined Heat and Power (CHP):**
 - Electrical output: 5,000–7,000 kWh/day
 - Thermal recovery: 15,000–20,000 kWh/day
 - Combined efficiency: 75–80%

Note: Detailed stepwise calculations are presented in Appendix A, including biogas flow estimations, calorific value assessments, and energy balances.

12.2 Emissions Reduction Analysis

The system's environmental performance was assessed through GHG accounting:

Source	Baseline CO ₂ e (t/year)	Post-Project CO ₂ e (t/year)	Reduction (%)
Landfill methane	6,200	0	100%
Natural gas displacement	4,500	2,100	53%
Electricity offset	2,800	1,600	43%
Total	13,500	3,700	73%

Figure 12.1 illustrates the GHG reduction comparison, showing the major contribution of avoided landfill methane and natural gas displacement.

12.3 Financial Model

A financial analysis was conducted using CAPEX, OPEX, and revenue from energy savings and carbon credits:

Parameter	Value (CAD)
Capital Expenditure (CAPEX)	12.5 M
Annual Operating Costs (OPEX)	1.35 M
Annual Revenue (Energy + Carbon Credits)	0.85 M
Net Present Value (NPV, 20 years)	6.2 M
Internal Rate of Return (IRR)	9.2%
Payback Period	7.8 years

The project meets the financial viability targets with a positive NPV and IRR above the minimum threshold, making it economically feasible.

12.4 Sensitivity Analysis

Key parameters were varied to understand system robustness:

Parameter	Range Tested	Impact on Payback Period
Biogas yield $\pm 10\%$	6,750–10,780 m ³ /day	7.2–8.5 years
Electricity price $\pm 15\%$	0.08–0.12 CAD/kWh	7.0–8.3 years
CAPEX $\pm 10\%$	11.25–13.75 M	7.3–8.2 years

The analysis shows the system remains financially viable under realistic variations, demonstrating resilience to market and operational fluctuations.

12.5 Recommendations & Next Steps

1. **Pilot Implementation:** Test the integrated system on a smaller scale (10–15 t/day) before full deployment.
2. **Automation Enhancement:** Improve SCADA-based control for optimized feedstock management and real-time energy balancing.
3. **Continuous Monitoring:** Establish emission and energy monitoring protocols to ensure regulatory compliance.
4. **Digestate Quality Testing:** Regular nutrient analysis to guarantee suitability as fertilizer.
5. **Stakeholder Engagement:** Educate staff on system operation and maintain strong OEM support contracts.

13. Conclusion

The proposed integrated waste-to-energy system demonstrates strong technical, environmental, and financial viability for the Canadian food processing industry:

- **Energy Recovery:** 25–35% of electricity demand and 60–80% of thermal demand offset.
- **GHG Reduction:** Approximately 40–50% reduction in CO₂e emissions, supporting federal 2030 climate targets.
- **Waste Minimization:** More than 90% of organic waste diverted from landfill.
- **Financial Feasibility:** Positive NPV, IRR above 8%, and payback within 7–10 years.
- **Circular Economy Benefits:** Closed-loop model generating energy, fertilizer, and reducing dependence on fossil fuels.

This capstone project provides a **replicable framework** for sustainable food processing operations, aligning with Canada's national climate objectives and fostering long-term industrial sustainability.